

Interactive Storytelling

Experience and Exploration

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NORMAL STORY

A character finds a lost wallet.

They keep it.
You watch what happens.

INTERACTIVE STORY

You find a lost wallet.

KEEP IT

RETURN IT

What changes before the plot changes?



Viewer and participant

“What will the character do?”

becomes

“What should I do?”

Interactivity moves the audience inside the decision.

EXPLICIT CHOICE

The story asks directly.

HELP THEM

WALK AWAY

A visible menu labels the decision.

IMPLICIT CHOICE

The story watches what you do.

You stop and help.

You keep walking.

Your action becomes the answer.

Choice can appear as a prompt or emerge through behavior.

Environmental storytelling

NORMAL STORY

**“The family left
in a hurry.”**

The story tells you.

INTERACTIVE STORY



**unfinished meal
open suitcase
photographs removed**

The space lets you infer it.

Objects, sound, lighting, and layout can carry the narrative.

Exploration as storytelling

You enter an empty house. Where do you go first?



BEDROOM

personal history



OFFICE

public conflict



BASEMENT

hidden secret

Where the player goes determines what part of the story they discover.

Emotion through responsibility

FILM

A character dies.

“I watched it happen.”

INTERACTIVE STORY

**A character dies
after your choice.**

“Did I cause this?”

Participation can create guilt, attachment, doubt, or pride.

Information changes the meaning of a choice

Do you trust Alex?

PLAYER 1

Skipped the hidden room

Chooses with limited information

PLAYER 2

Found proof that Alex lied

Chooses with new context

The option is identical. The decision is not.

TRADITIONAL GAME FAILURE

You failed.

Restart and try again.

INTERACTIVE NARRATIVE

You failed.

**The story continues
with that consequence.**

*Failure becomes part of your version of
the story.*

NORMAL STORY

**A friend is trapped.
The hero hesitates.**

You feel suspense.

INTERACTIVE STORY

Your friend is trapped.

SAVE THEM RUN

3...

You feel pressure.

Author control and player agency

THE AUTHOR CONTROLS

available actions
possible consequences
where paths can end

THE PLAYER CONTROLS

what to explore
when to act
which path feels personal

The player has limited freedom inside a designed world.

How much control does the player really have?

The author controls the possibilities.

The player controls the experience.

Interactive storytelling gives us enough control to feel responsible for what happens.